

Patient Fact Sheet: Ovarian Cancer Detection

What every woman should know about screening, the Pap test, symptoms, and when to seek care

1. What the Pap test screens for

2. No routine ovarian screening

3. How detection works

4. Symptoms to watch for

5. What to say to your doctor

6. Higher risk factors

What does the Pap test actually screen for?

A Pap test takes a small sample of cells from the cervix (the lower part of the uterus). It looks for changes that could turn into cervical cancer. It is a strong, proven test for cervical cancer.

A Pap test takes a small sample of cells from the cervix (the lower part of the uterus). It looks for changes that could turn into cervical cancer. It is a strong, proven test for cervical cancer.

COMMON MYTH

My Pap test came back normal, so I know I don't have ovarian cancer.

THE FACT

A normal Pap result tells you about your cervix only. It provides no information about your ovaries.

Is there a routine screening test for ovarian cancer?

No. Right now, there is no proven test to screen every woman for ovarian cancer if she has average risk and no symptoms.

This is not just a Canadian issue; it is true globally. Large studies tested for a protein in the blood that can go up with ovarian cancer tumor marker blood test (CA-125) and did a transvaginal ultrasound (an ultrasound done from inside the vagina). They found that neither one lowered ovarian cancer deaths in the public. Both tests can give a wrong "positive" result. That can lead to surgery a woman did not need.

Health Canada

Does not recommend routine ovarian cancer screening for average-risk women.

American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists (ACOG)

Committee Opinion 716 says there is no effective screening test for average-risk women and recommends symptom-based evaluation including bloating, pelvic pain, and urinary changes as the pathway to investigation.

American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists (ACOG)

Suggests testing only when symptoms appear, not screening every woman.

Myth: I can ask for a CA-125 blood test to screen for ovarian cancer every year.

Fact: CA-125 is a useful diagnostic tool when symptoms are present but is not recommended as a screening test for average-risk women.

How detection works and what symptoms to watch for

How is ovarian cancer detected?

Since there is no routine screening test, finding it early depends on your ability to recognize symptoms that are new, happen often, and keep coming back. Tell your doctor right away.

When you seek care with concerning symptoms, your doctor may order a pelvic exam, transvaginal ultrasound, or CA-125 blood test as part of a diagnostic investigation. These tools investigate a concern. They are not the same as routine screening.

Higher risk?

Women with a BRCA1/2 mutation or strong family history should speak with their doctor about a personalized monitoring plan.

Symptoms to watch for

The key is not the symptom type alone. It is whether they are new, frequent, and persistent compared to what's normal for you.

Bloating present most days

Unexplained fatigue or low energy

Pelvic or abdominal pain or pressure

Changes in bowel habits

Difficulty eating or feeling full quickly

Unexplained weight loss or abdominal swelling

Urinary urgency or frequency

Pain during sex

THE 3-WEEK GUIDELINE

Symptoms present more days than not for 3 or more weeks? See your doctor. You do not need to wait for an annual exam.

What to do and what to say to your doctor

Many women wait to get care. The symptoms can feel too small to mention, or they may think a recent Pap test or pelvic exam would have caught a problem. These feelings are understandable, but they should not stop you from asking questions.

Your action plan

1 Keep a symptom diary

Write down which symptoms you have, how often, and whether they feel different from your normal. Even one week of notes helps your doctor see a pattern.

2 Book a separate appointment

Call your family doctor or nurse practitioner. Do not wait for your yearly exam. . Book a visit to talk about your symptoms.

3 Be direct with your doctor

Say: "I have had [symptom] most days for the past [number] weeks. It feels different from my normal. I would like to talk about whether we should look into it."

4 Ask specifically about ovarian cancer

You can say: "Is it possible these symptoms could be related to my ovaries? What would be the next step to find out?"

5 Seek a second opinion if needed

If you feel your concern is not being heard, it is okay to ask to see a gynecologist (a doctor for women's health) or to get a second opinion.

Higher risk factors and where to learn more

Are you at higher risk?

While most ovarian cancer occurs in women with no family history, some factors increase risk. Speak with your doctor about a personalized plan if any of the following apply to you:

- Known BRCA1 or BRCA2 gene mutation
- Family history of ovarian, breast, or colorectal cancer in a first-degree relative
- Lynch syndrome gene mutation
- Personal history of breast cancer

Higher-risk individuals may be offered surveillance, genetic counselling, or discussions about risk-reduction options. These are tailored to your individual circumstances, not population screening.

Where to learn more

These Canadian and international organizations provide reliable, evidence-based information.

Ovarian Cancer Canada

ovariancanada.org
1-877-413-7970

Canadian Cancer Society

cancer.ca

NICE guideline NG12

nice.org.uk/guidance/ng12
Symptom-triggered investigation guidance

ACOG Committee Opinion 716

acog.org
Role of OB-GYN in early ovarian cancer detection

UHN Gynecologic Oncology Program

gynoncuhn.ca